



Congo, (DRC)

Lying in east-central Africa, the Democratic Republic of the Congo (DRC) is one of Africa's largest countries, and the scene of one of its worst regional wars.



GEOGRAPHY

Rainforested basin of Congo River occupies 60% of the land area. High mountain ranges and lakes stretch down the eastern border.



CLIMATE

Tropical and humid. Distinct wet and dry seasons south of the equator. The north is mainly wet.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

There are 12 main ethnic groups and around 190 smaller ones. The indigenous forest pygmies, victimized in the war, are now a marginalized group. Civil war from 1996 drew neighboring countries into a bloody conflict. Tentative peace in 2003 was soon undermined by rebels in the east.



INSIGHT: The DRC's rainforests comprise 6% of the world's, and 50% of Africa's, remaining woodlands



THE ECONOMY

Rich resource base: minerals (copper, coltan, cobalt, diamonds) dominate export earnings. War and decades of corruption have caused economic collapse. Food aid is needed to ease humanitarian crisis.



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Democratic Republic of the Congo

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Kinshasa

POPULATION: 66 million

TOTAL AREA: 905,563 sq. miles
(2,345,410 sq. km)

DENSITY: 75 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Kiswahili, Tshiluba, French*

RELIGIONS: Christian 70%, Kimbanguist 10%, traditional beliefs 10%, Muslim 10%

ETHNIC MIX: Other 55%, Mongo, Luba, Kongo, and Mangbetu-Azande 45%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: Congolese franc = 100 centimes